

Gujarati, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Gujarati one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Gujarati letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read નમસ્તે *and* learn what it means in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Gujarati simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Gujarati (*gujarātī*) is an **Indo-Aryan** language — a granddaughter of Sanskrit, like Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali — and the mother tongue of some sixty million people in Gujarat and across a famous global diaspora. It is the language of **Mahatma Gandhi**, who wrote his autobiography in it. Its script is Devanagari’s sister with one visible difference: it dropped the horizontal *top line*, so its letters float free — “the headless script.” Two threads run through the book: Gujarati’s Sanskrit inheritance (shared with Hindi), and the deep **Perso-Arabic** layer it took on as one of India’s great trading tongues (so “I’m well” is answered with the Persian *majā*, “relish”). Roots are traced to Sanskrit, to Persian/Arabic, and, where they reach, to the wider family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Gujarati out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in

brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Gujarati greetings — and, taught through them, how to read a script that is Devanagari’s sister, but bareheaded. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/GU-C01-*.md.*

1.1 નમસ્તે (*namaste*) — “hello,” and a script with no ceiling

The letters in this word

(If you already read Gujarati, skim this.) Gujarati runs **left to right**; every consonant carries a built-in “a”: ન na, મા ma, સા sa, ત ta. A *virama* joins consonants: સા + ્ + ત → સ્ત. Above all: Gujarati has **no top line**. Devanagari, Bengali, and Gurmukhi hang letters from a bar (the *shirorekhā*); Gujarati cut it away — “the headless script.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

નમસ્તે (*namaste*) is Sanskrit *namas* (“a bow”) + *te* (“to you”) — “I bow to you,” the very word Hindi and Sanskrit use. Gujarati is **Indo-Aryan**, a granddaughter of Sanskrit, so it inherited the greeting whole. (The everyday Hindu hello is often કેમ છો? *kem chho?*, “how are you?” — Chapter 3.)

1.2 આભાર (*ābhār*) — “thank you,” an obligation gladly owed

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

આભાર (*ābhār*, “thanks”) is from Sanskrit *ābhāra* (“a burden, an obligation”), *ā-* (“toward”) + the root *bhr̥* (“to bear, carry”). To thank is to acknowledge you now *bear an obligation* — the idea behind English **oblige** and Portuguese *obrigado*. That root *bhr̥* is PIE *b^her-, the ancestor of English **bear** (to carry) and Latin *ferre*.

1.3 હા / ના (*hā / nā*) — “yes” and “no”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

હા (*hā*, “yes”) and ના (*nā*, “no”). The “no” rides the ancient negative *na-* — the same PIE *ne behind English **no**, **not**, **none**, Latin *nōn*, Hindi *nahī̃*. One syllable spoken, in some form, from Iceland to Gujarat for five thousand years.

1.4 સારું (*sārũ*) — “good,” “okay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

સારું (*sārũ*, “good, fine, okay”) is from Sanskrit *sāra* (“essence, the best part”) — the same *sāra* behind Bengali’s *sāramilla*. As “okay/agreed” it oils every conversation.

Grammar Lens

Three genders, on the adjective. That -સારું (-*ũ*) ending is **neuter**. Gujarati, like Marathi, keeps three genders (Hindi kept two): *sāro* (m.) / *sārī* (f.) / *sārũ* (n.). Standing alone, “okay” is the neuter *sārũ*.

1.5 આવજો (*āvjo*) — “goodbye” (come again)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

આવજો (*āvjo*) is the polite imperative of આવવું (*āvṽṽ*, “to come”) — literally “[please] come [again].” A Gujarati never signs off with “I’m leaving”; the parting word is *come*. It is the subcontinent’s “promise of return” (Tamil *pōy varugirēṇ*, Bengali *āshi*, Hindi *phir milenge*), here made a single warm word on the verb *to come*. (Familiarly: આવજે *āvje*.)

1.6 Recap

Gujarati		Meaning
નમસ્તે	<i>namaste</i>	hello / goodbye
આભાર	<i>ābhār</i>	thank you
હા / ના	<i>hā / nā</i>	yes / no
સારું	<i>sārũ</i>	good / okay
આવજો	<i>āvjo</i>	goodbye (“come again”)

Two things set Gujarati apart already: the **missing top line** (the “headless” script) and its **three genders** (*sāro/sārī/sārũ*). Roots banked: *ābhār* (*bhr̥* “to bear,” cousin of English *bear*), *nā* (PIE **ne*, English *no*), *āvjo* (“come again,” from *āvṽṽ*). Next chapter: introducing yourself.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

મારું નામ મીરા છે. (*mārũ nām Mīra chhe* — “My name is Mira.”)
તમારું નામ શું છે? (*tamārũ nām shũ chhe* — “What is your name?”)

Practice lessons: lessons/GU-C02-.md.*

2.1 નામ (*nām*) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

નામ (*nām*) ← Sanskrit *nāman*, from PIE **h₃nómn*. — the same root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (→ **noun**), Greek *onoma*, Hindi *nām*. Cousins from before either language existed.

2.2 મારું (*mārũ*) — “my,” and gender again

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

મારું (*mārũ*, “my”) is on the first-person root *ma-* — the same behind English **me**, **my**, **mine**, Latin *meus*, Hindi *merā*.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees in three genders. *nām* is neuter, so “my name” is *mārũ nām*. The set: *māro* (m.) / *mārī* (f.) / *mārũ* (n.). Every possessive

picks its form from the noun’s gender.

2.3 છે (chhe) — “is,” a copula all Gujarati’s own

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

છે (chhe, “is”) is Gujarati’s **copula** — and, unusually, *not* Hindi’s *hai* or Sanskrit’s *asti*. It grew from an Old Gujarati form (*achhai*) along its own path, so it quickly marks a sentence as Gujarati. Its forms: *hũ chhũ* (I am), *tũ chhe* (you are), *te chhe* (is), *tame chho* (you are, resp.).

Grammar Lens

The verb goes last. Gujarati is subject–object–verb: “my name Arun *is*.” *Chhe* sits at the end.

2.4 મારું નામ...છે — “my name is...”

મારું (my) + નામ (name) + નામ + છે (is) = “my name is...” *Mārũ nām Arun chhe*. The verb comes last; *mārũ* is neuter to agree with *nām*.

2.5 તું / તમે (tũ / tame) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

તું (tũ, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, PIE *tū — the root of English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*, Hindi *tū*. તમે (tame, respectful) is grammatically plural — courtesy-by-plural, like French *vous*; it takes the plural copula *chho*.

2.6 શું (*shũ*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

શું (*shũ*, “what”) descends, by a winding road, from the interrogative stem *ka-* (PIE **k^wo-*) — the root behind English **what**, Latin *quis*, Hindi *kyā*. Most Gujarati questions still show the *k-* plainly (*kem* how, *kōṇ* who, *kyāṇ* where, *kyāre* when); “what” wore down to this *sh-* form — the odd cousin in a *k-* family.

2.7 તમારું નામ શું છે? — “what’s your name?”

તમારું (*tamārũ*, “your,” neuter to match *nām*) + નામ + શું (what) + છે (is) = “your name what is?” — verb last. The familiar “your” is *tārũ* (from *tũ*). Note *mārũ* / *tārũ* / *tamārũ* — “my / your / your (resp.),” all neuter before *nām*.

2.8 આનંદ (*ānand*) — “joy,” and “a joy to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The full phrase is તમને મળીને આનંદ થયો (*tamne maḷīne ānand thayo*) — “having met you, joy happened.” આનંદ (*ānand*, “joy, bliss”) is **Sanskrit** — *ā-* (“fully”) + *nand* (“to rejoice”) — the *ānanda* of *sat-cit-ānanda* and a common Gujarati name.

2.9 The whole exchange

Gujarati	English
મારું નામ મીરા છે.	My name is Mira.
તમારું નામ શું છે?	What’s your name?
મારું નામ અરુણ છે.	My name is Arun.
તમને મળીને આનંદ થયો.	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nām* (→ *name*), *mārũ* (→ *my*), *shũ* (→ *what*), *tũ* (→ *thou*). And *chhe* — Gujarati’s own “is,” not Hindi’s *hai*. Next chapter: *tame kem chho?* (“how are you?”).

Chapter 3

How Are You?

For most Gujaratis this is the real everyday hello:

તમે કેમ છો? (*tame kem chho* — “How are you?”)
હું મજામાં છું, આભાર. (*hũ majāmām chhũ, ābhār* — “I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/GU-C03-.md.*

3.1 કેમ (*kem*) — “how,” a proper k- question

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

કેમ (*kem*, “how”; also “why”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. It heads the plain *k-* family Gujarati kept: *kem* (how), *kōṇ* (who), *kyām* (where), *kyāre* (when). And કેમ છો? is, for most Gujaratis, the real everyday hello.

3.2 તમે કેમ છો? — “how are you?”

તમે (*tame*, respectful “you”) + કેમ (how) + છો (*chho*, “are”) — “you how are?”, verb last. *Chho* is the respectful/plural form of the copula *chhe* from Chapter 2. To a friend: તું કેમ છે? (*tũ kem chhe?*).

3.3 હું (*hũ*) — “I”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

હું (*hũ*, “I”) descends from Sanskrit *aham* (through Old Gujarati *haũ*). That *aham* is PIE **h₁eg(H)om* — the ancestor of Latin **ego** and English **I**. It takes the copula *chhũ* (“am”): *hũ ...chhũ*.

3.4 મજા (*majā*) — “enjoyment,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

મજા (*majā*, “enjoyment, relish, fun”) is **not** Sanskrit — it is **Perso-Arabic**, from Persian *maza* (“taste, relish”). Gujaratis, a great trading people, wove thousands of Persian and Arabic words into their speech across centuries of commerce over the Arabian Sea — and even “how are you” is answered with one: હું મજામાં છું (*hũ majāmāṃ chhũ*), literally “I am *in enjoyment*.”

3.5 વાંધો નહીં (*vāndho nahīm*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

વાંધો નહીં literally “[there is] **no objection**” — *vāndho* (“objection, difficulty”) + *nahīm*, “not”), the fuller form of Chapter 1’s *nā*. Both from the ancient *na-*, PIE **ne*, behind English **no**, **not**.

3.6 The whole exchange

Gujarati	English
તમે કેમ છો?	How are you?
હું મજામાં છું, આભાર.	I’m well, thank you.
વાંધો નહીં.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Roots banked: *kem* (the *k*- questions), *hũ* (*aham* → Latin *ego*, English *I*),

majā (**Persian** *maza* — the trade-language layer), *nahīm* (PIE *ne, English *no*). Next chapter: the farewells.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the quick આવજો (*āvjo*, “come again”). Its explicit companion:

પાછા મળીશું! (*pāchhā maḷīshũ* — “We’ll meet again!”)

Practice lessons: lessons/GU-CO4-.md.*

4.1 પાછા (*pāchhā*) — “again, back”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

પાછા (*pāchhā*, “back, again”) is from Sanskrit *paścāt* (“behind, afterward”). It carries the sense of *return*: *pāchhā āvvũ* (“to come back”). Add it to “we’ll meet” for the warm goodbye.

4.2 મળીશું (*maḷīshũ*) — “(we) will meet”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

મળીશું (*maḷīshũ*, “we will meet”) is the future of મળવું (*maḷvũ*, “to meet”), from Sanskrit *mil-* (“to join”) — the same root as Hindi *milnā*. Note the retroflex ળ (*ḷ*): Gujarati keeps this extra letter, like Marathi and the Dravidian south, unlike Hindi.

Grammar Lens

The future is an ending. *maḷ-* + *-īshũ* (“we will”) → *maḷīshũ* — no helper like English “will.”

4.3 પાછા મળીશું — “we’ll meet again”

પાછા (again) + મળીશું (we will meet) = “we’ll meet again” — the explicit form of Chapter 1’s *āvjo*, the subcontinent’s “promise of return” (Hindi *phir milenge*, Bengali *āshi*).

4.4 કાલે મળીશું (*kāle maḷīshũ*) — “see you tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

કાલ (*kāl*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit *kāla* (“time”), the root behind Hindi’s *kal* and Punjabi’s *akāl* (“timeless”). The tense tells which: *kāle maḷīshũ* (future → “tomorrow we’ll meet”).

4.5 The farewells

Gujarati	English
આવજો.	Goodbye. (“come again”)
પાછા મળીશું.	We’ll meet again.
કાલે મળીશું.	See you tomorrow.

Roots banked: *āvjo* (“come again,” from *āvvũ*), *maḷvũ* (“to meet,” Sanskrit *mil-*; the retroflex ળ), *kāl* (*kāla* “time,” cousin of Hindi *kal*, Punjabi *akāl*). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *hũ gujarātī bolũ chhũ*.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

હું ગુજરાતી બોલું છું. (*hũ gujarātī bolũ chhũ* — “I speak Gujarati.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/GU-C05-.md.*

5.1 બોલવું (*bolvũ*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

બોલવું (*bolvũ*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (the same *bol-* as Hindi *bolnā*, Punjabi *bolṇā*). Its ending -વું (*-vũ*) is Gujarati’s infinitive: *bol-vũ* “to speak,” *maḷ-vũ* “to meet,” *āv-vũ* “to come.” Strip it for the stem (*bol-*).

Grammar Lens

Stem + person + copula. *hũ bolũ chhũ* (I speak), *tũ bole chhe* (you speak), *tame bolo chho* (you, resp.), *te bole chhe* (he/she speaks). The plain present is the same for a man or a woman — Gujarati saves its **three genders** for adjectives and the past, not the simple present.

5.2 હું ગુજરાતી બોલું છું — “I speak Gujarati”

હું (I) + ગુજરાતી (*gujarātī*, the object) + બોલું છું (speak) — “I Gujarati speak,” verb last. The name ગુજરાત (*Gujarāt*) comes from the **Gurjar**, a people who entered western India around the 6th–8th centuries and gave their name to the land (*Gurjara-deśa* → *Gujarāt*); *gujarātī* is “[the language] of Gujarat.”

5.3 રહેવું (*rahevũ*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

રહેવું (*rahevũ*, “to live, remain, stay”), from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain,” the same as Hindi *rahnā*): *hũ Amdāvādmām rahũ chhũ* (“I live in Ahmedabad”).

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. અમદાવાદમાં (*Amdāvādmām*) = *Ahmedabad* + *-mām* (“in”), on the noun’s *end*. Gujarati uses **postpositions**, verb last.

5.4 કામ કરવું (*kām karvũ*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

કરવું (*karvũ*, “to do, make”) is from Sanskrit *kr̥* (“to do”), PIE **k^wer-* — the root of Chapter 1’s family: *namaskār* (“the *making* of a bow”), *karma* (“a thing *done*”). And કામ (*kām*, “work”) is itself from Sanskrit *karma*. Gujarati builds compounds as **noun** + કરવું: કામ કરવું (*kām karvũ*, “work-do” = “to work”). So *hũ kām karũ chhũ* = “I work” — the twin of Hindi’s *kām karnā* and Bengali’s *kāj karā*.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Gujarati	English
હું ગુજરાતી બોલું છું.	I speak Gujarati.
હું અમદાવાદમાં રહું છું.	I live in Ahmedabad.
હું કામ કરું છું.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a person-ending, the copula forms *chhũ*, *chhe*, and *chho* — the verb always last, “in” after its noun. Roots banked: *bolvũ* (native), *rahevũ* (*rah-* “remain”), *karvũ* (*kr̥* — root of *namaskār*, *karma*; *kām* “work” ← *karma*), and *gujarātī* (the *Gurjar* people). From here, Gujarati — the tongue of Gandhi — only opens further.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

6.1 એક, બે, ત્રણ, ચાર, પાંચ — one to five

Three of these will look familiar from any other Indian language.
Two won't — and both have a reason.

You'll want to know: the five

	Gujarati	said
1	એક	<i>ek</i>
2	બે	<i>be</i>
3	ત્રણ	<i>traṇ</i>
4	ચાર	<i>chār</i>
5	પાંચ	<i>pāch</i>

Notice the script: Gujarati is Devanagari **without the top line**. Same letters, same system — the shirorekha simply isn't drawn. If you've done the Hindi writing track you can feel the relationship immediately.

What you've built: two surprises and a headless script

Most neighbouring languages have a *d* in “two,” but Gujarati says બે *be*. Hindi says *tīn* for “three,” but Gujarati says ત્રણ *traṇ*, with an *r*. Do not carry both histories while the count is still new. Make the five forms automatic first; the next prerequisite-ordered lesson explains why *be* and *traṇ* took those shapes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ek, be, traṇ, chār, pāch”
- the odd two — Gujarati **be** and **traṇ**
- the script clue — Devanagari shapes without a top line

Before you move on

Count to five in Gujarati. (*Ek, be, traṇ, chār, pāch.*) Why does **૨** look unlike its neighbours? (It begins with *b*, not *d*.) What does **૨૩૧** contain that Hindi *tīn* does not? (*r*.) What is visibly missing from the Gujarati script? (The top line: the *shirorekhā* is not drawn.) Next: trace the two surprising number histories.

6.2 Two number histories: *be* and *traṇ*

Count once: *ek, be, traṇ, chār, pāch*. Which two forms look least like Hindi or Marathi? (*Be* and *traṇ*.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Sanskrit had gendered forms of “two,” and its daughters selected different parts of that paradigm:

language	“two”	route
Sanskrit	<i>dváu</i> (masc.) · <i>dvé</i> (fem. and neut.)	—
Hindi	<i>do</i>	masculine side
Marathi	<i>don</i>	masculine side, plus an analogical <i>-n</i>
Bengali	<i>dui</i>	disyllabic Prakrit <i>duve</i>
Gujarati	<i>be</i>	feminine/neuter <i>dvé</i> side

Gujarati **૨** is not a corruption of *do*. It is a **different inheritance** from the same Sanskrit paradigm.

The initial cluster changed too. In *dv-*, the dental *d* adopted the **labial place** of the following *v*: *dv* → *bb* → *b*. The first consonant was remade in the shape of its neighbour, then the double simplified.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

stage	“three”
Sanskrit neuter	<i>trīṇi</i>
Prakrit	<i>tiṇṇi</i> : <i>r</i> already gone
Hindi	<i>tīn</i>
Gujarati	<i>tran</i> : <i>r</i> present again

The shared **ṇ** shows that Hindi and Gujarati both descend from neuter *trīṇi* through Prakrit *tiṇṇi*. By that stage, the *r* was gone and its weight had moved into doubled *ṇṇ*. Hindi later simplified the double and lengthened the vowel.

Gujarati’s *tr-* is generally treated as **restored from Sanskrit**, not carried through unbroken. Sanskrit remained a literary language and continued to reshape its descendants. *Tran* looks older than *tīn*, but it is closer because speakers put the *r* back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- Gujarati’s selected form — feminine/neuter *dvé*
- the sound path — *dv* → *bb* → *b*
- the *r* path — *trīṇi* → *tiṇṇi* → *tran*
- inherited continuously or restored — restored

Before you move on

Why *be*, not Hindi *do*? (Different Sanskrit forms.) What changed in *dv* → *b*? (*D* became labial beside *v*; the double simplified.) Did *tran* keep *r*? (No: Sanskrit restored Prakrit’s lost *r*.) How can a newer form look older? (Learned restoration.)

The Gujarati script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words.
This page gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ક ka, ન na, મા ma — written left to right. The shapes are Devanagari’s, minus one thing (see below).
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** કા kā, કિ ki, કી kī, કુ ku, કે ke, કો ko. The *i*-sign િ is written *before* the consonant but read *after* it. An *anusvāra* ં nasalises the vowel.
3. **A *virama* removes the vowel**, and the bare consonant joins the next as a conjunct: રા + ં + દ → રદ.

Worth flagging

- **No top line.** This is the one thing to remember. Devanagari, Bengali, and Gurmukhi hang their letters from a horizontal bar (the *shirorekha*); Gujarati cut it away, so its letters stand free. It is the fastest way to tell Gujarati from Hindi at a glance — “the headless script.”
- **The extra letter ળ (ḷ).** A **retroflex l**, tongue curled back — shared with Marathi and the Dravidian south, absent from Hindi. It appears in *maḷvū* (“to meet”).
- **Three genders.** Gujarati keeps Sanskrit’s masculine, feminine, *and* neuter (Hindi collapsed to two), marking gender on adjectives and possessives: *sāro* (m.) / *sārī* (f.) / *sārū* (n.).

Gujarati in the family

Gujarati is **Indo-Aryan** (from Sanskrit, like Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, Bengali), spoken in Gujarat and across a large diaspora — the mother tongue of Mahatma Gandhi. Its Sanskrit core is shared with Hindi; its heavy **Perso-Arabic** layer (and a few Portuguese words from the coastal ports) is the mark of centuries as a great trading language across the Arabian Sea. The lessons trace both threads.